



**The Effects of Traumatic In-Group Behavioral Fluency on Late-Stage First Language  
Acquisition**

M.Sc. Thesis

Nika Leninovna Chilikov

Thesis Advisor

Prof. Dr. Sarah Brice

University of North Carolina Charlotte

Department of Psychological Science

M.Sc. Child Psychology

## **ABSTRACT**

A litter of handwritten and printed pages comprise a manuscript version of Nika Leninovna Chilikov's master's thesis in child psychology. Only the abstract, first few pages, and bibliography are complete. Chilikov's subjects are the children shipped from Maryland to the King-Torino Children's Refuge. Each is given a simple moniker ("Sub. A," "Sub. B," etc.) to protect anonymity. The "Methods" section, which describes each child, makes it clear Chilikov included herself in the study. The consulting Ph.D. on the thesis is Sarah Brice, who worked at King-Torino and signed off on the use of her case files. Brice died of a brain tumor in 2012. The thrust of Chilikov's argument is that under certain extreme conditions of educational neglect and physical abuse, housing victims together may actually impede their development of language skills. She explains that strict in-group norms forged in the abusive environment can severely alter behavior and communication. The paper recounts, through a veil of objectivity, Chilikov's own struggles after accepting the tutelage of Dr. Brice, the violence she endured at the hands of her former friends, and her slow progress in education despite enormous pressure to shut down.

## 1. INTRODUCTION

Chilikov's notes include a few sketches of drawings left by the children: A small, childlike figure with red hands stands triumphant over larger, adult victims all lying in blood. Their number is six. The head of each victim has a red splotch that might represent the brain. Other children and small animals watch in a crowd. A pole with a pair of horns atop it. The half-circle of the sun, radiating lines of light, halos the symbol, half crested over a horizon line. The moon over a nondescript line of horizon. Stars dot the background, in a uniform pattern across all instances of the image. A dead tree in a distinctive shape, empty limbs curling, is silhouetted in the foreground against the moon. A campfire seen through a thicket of skinny trees. A black head containing a red brain.

She cannot decipher their meaning. The "red brain" design appears most often. The subjects drew or painted it only when they were separated for lengths of time, leaving symbols for each other in a playroom. It first appeared in 2004 outside the office of Dr. Brice, whom the subjects loathed and feared for trying to help them communicate. In 2006, one of them drew it on a sketch of a particularly brutal caretaker. In 2007, one of them drew it on every copy of a cheery, cartoonish pamphlet that encouraged children to trust police.



Figure 1

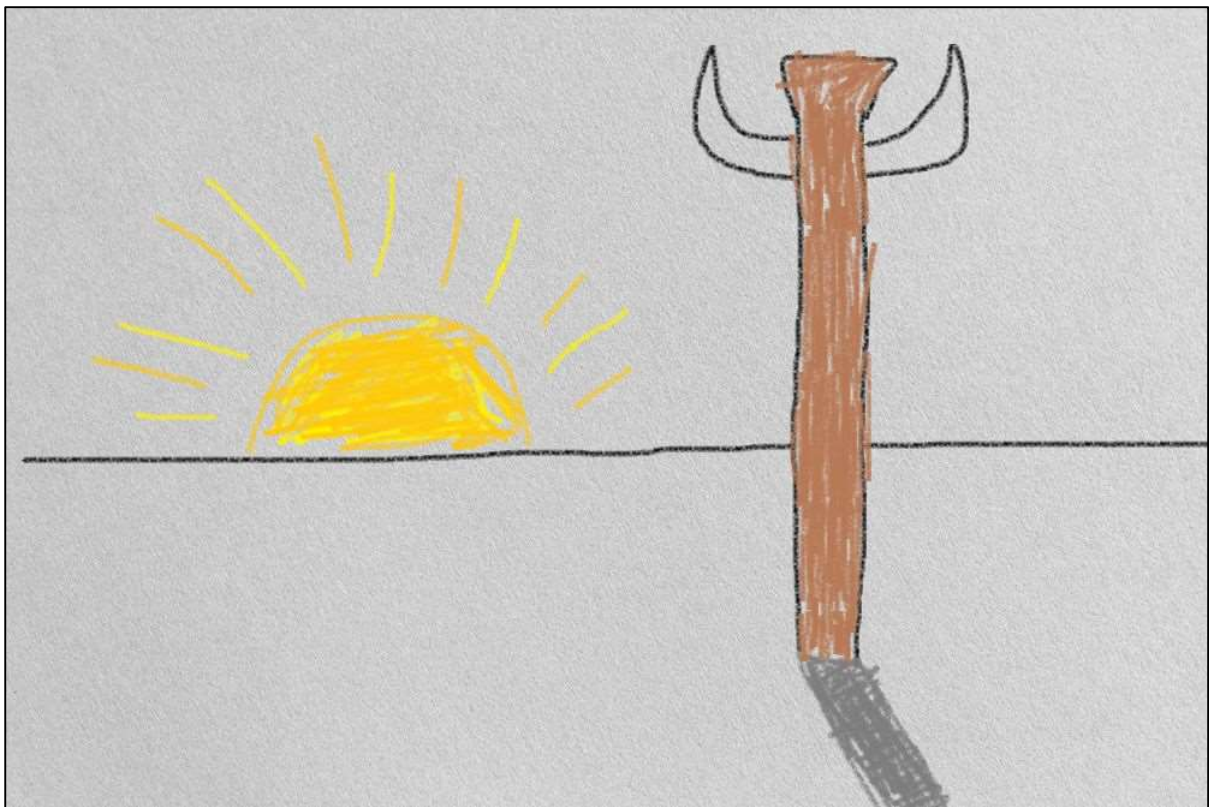


Figure 2





Figure 3



Figure 4





**Figure 5, “The Red Brain”**

## 5. CONCLUSION

The thesis a remarkable example of psychological insight, perseverance, and bad research ethics. Chilikov connects a series of widely disparate theorists, referencing Sapir-Whorf, Piaget, Vygotsky, and Green. However, the researcher's personal involvement in the case makes it all but impossible to publish. Chilikov secretly used her own childhood experiences to craft a compelling research subject, lying about her personal involvement in order to get the thesis abstract approved. Even worse, it is partially plagiarized. The young woman preferred working on paper with pen, printing out everything she needed in a collage of dead tree rather than leaving it on the screen.

Included in the nest of documents is an extensive email exchange with one "ScribeLife420," the Internet handle of a freelancer she found through PaperMill.us, an online essay farm that composes bespoke essays, proofed against plagiarism, for students at a price. Chilikov also saved copies of the conversations in printed form for quick reference. While Chilikov's ideas and analysis are her own, her struggles with late language acquisition hampered her academic progress severely. The email includes patches of text, inexpertly composed with limited vocabulary, misspellings, and numerous agreement errors, that she sent to ScribeLife420. Chilikov's jumbled text would never pass muster at the graduate level, but ScribeLife420 sent back concise paragraphs using field-appropriate vocabulary, paraphrasing the student's own ideas. ScribeLife420 also appears to have translated a number of passages for Nika that she sent to him via screenshot.

Chilikov and ScribeLife420 appear to have been introduced through an acquaintance called only Conradin. ScribeLife420 was the first to send an email, claiming that Conradin informed PaperMill.us that Chilikov might need his services after the death of Dr. Brice. There is no other mention of the name in the files. Nika and the plagiarist have been corresponding all semester and making progress.